

Episode 25: Once Upon a Time... (20) *Saint Seiya* Part 7 – Theatrical *Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods* A Bit More, and Stories about Special Effects Staff

I took about 2 weeks off from the series, and during this time I couldn't escape to cool highlands for summer retreat (cries) - I've been spending incredibly busy days. In this brutal heat too...

I successfully completed the move in this heat and now enjoy comfortable new home days, but perhaps due to age I got hit hard with fatigue and came down with summer cold for about 2 days. With fever exceeding the "temperature higher than body temperature brutal heat," I was delirious (bitter laugh).

Thankfully the summer cold cleared up and I'm in perfect condition now.

This summer I've been sweating abnormally, no matter how many T-shirts I change they're soaked immediately. I'm sweating more than ever in my personal history, but with all this sweating, why don't I lose weight? (wails)

Such is the middle of lingering summer heat in Tokyo (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Let me write a bit more about theatrical "*Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods*".

There's a process called "special effects" in finishing work processes.

Using airbrushes, brushes, sponges, dry brushes, spattering - utilising every technique possible to apply expressions of natural phenomena like light and wind, plus various material textures to painted cels. Literally handwork. It requires various skills and sense.

Recently, since photography became digital, it's often worked on as part of photography processing, but in this cel era, it was all finishing work.

So for TV series there were often pressures or directives like "try not to use too much" (bitter laugh).

Seiya is a work that can't exist without these special effects. Moreover, being theatrical work, we could really request it openly (laughs).

First, material texture expression. For example, **Saint Cloth** texture. **Seiya** and other **Bronze Saints'** cloths don't get much texture brush work, but **Gold Saints'** gold cloth textures and black lustrous cloth sheens are special effects brush work.

Drawn sword blade textures are also brush work. The silver goblet held by leader **Dolbar** in the opening also has texture brushing.

Also, rocks and debris crumbling and scattering during battles, bark textures of split and peeled tree trunks - these natural object textures are special effects. They draw additions over cels matching background touches. Raging blizzards and ice frost - such natural phenomena expressions are also special effects power.

Plus light and shadow expressions. Since it's a work with lots of fighting (laughs), there's glowing everywhere, so light expressions and shadow expressions receiving that light require special effects brushing. Sometimes direct so-called "light brushing" is applied, but for photography transmitted light processing, those transmitted light masks also get black brushing to blur light edges - that's special effects work too.

Oh yes, cel ground shadows were also mostly brush processing.

Expressing such effects requires first observational skills - "how do things appear?" - imaginative skills - "how to show it?" - plus technical skills and "artistic sense" to actually do the work.

Honestly, very time-consuming work. For example, airbrushes. First masking work to select brush areas. Using much thinner cels than colouring cels, starting by making masks cut from those sections. The more animation sheets, the more difficult, and demanding special effects or special techniques makes necessary masks more complex.

Also, since too many cel layers interfere with photography, sometimes effects must be added directly to coloured cels, making it difficult to redo work.

And teamwork. Especially for big jobs like theatrical works, special effects staff divide up the work to finish piece by piece. True specialists.

In this theatrical "*Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods*", the climax scene where **Frey** stabs his sword into the **Odin** statue and massive collapse occurs in light was especially difficult. Flowing cut connections, beautiful powerful animation, colourful backgrounds, and photography that beautifully captured light and shadow. Cel colours and special effects that fit perfectly within that. It's my favourite scene.

However, here I made a big mistake.

In the series of cuts where **Frey** climbs the statue and stabs it with his sword, I made a colour direction error in one cut. A cut needing light reflection from the **Odin** statue was finished in colours without reflection. I missed this during checking and had texture brushing applied with special effects in the wrong colours.

During **saridashi** (compositing), **Yamauchi** director noticed. Naturally I was called. Here the director thoroughly scolded me. Obviously we couldn't photograph it as-is, so cel colours, special effects - everything had to be redone.

"They did such careful brushing work - you understand how much effort that takes, don't you?" Those director's words I remember so clearly I can almost hear them now. Truly "face burning with shame" (bitter laugh).

Incidentally, it's properly retaken in the main story, so now only I know about this (laughs).

Every time I rewatch "*Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods*", what I first remember is **Frey**'s sword's magnificent special effects and **Yamauchi** director's words.

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